life, preferring to compose religious writings, while leaving the administration of his kingdom to his son Uzana (r. ca. 1250–1254). The power behind the throne during Kyaswa's reign, Uzana was killed by an elephant in a hunting accident in Dala shortly into his reign. Following Uzana's untimely death, his youngest son Narathihapati (r. ca. 1254–1287) was placed on the throne by the ambitious chief court minister Yazathingyan, who believed he could control the young prince. Once Narathihapati assumed the throne he promptly exiled Yazathingyan. Narathihapati would be the last ruler of Bagan, ending the nearly 250-year rule of Bagan over the Ayeyarwaddy River basin.

THE MONGOL INVASIONS

Following the subjugation of the Dali kingdom of Yunnan (937–1253) in 1253, Kublai Khan sent an envoy to Burma to demand tribute and allegiance from the Burmese king. According to some sources, Narathihapati refused to meet the first of the emissaries. Two years later Kublai Khan sent three more envoys to demand tribute. This time Narathihapati executed the envoys and sent their heads back to Kublai Khan. Confident of victory and emboldened by the lack of response from Kublai Khan, Narathihapati invaded the neighboring state of Kaungai in 1277. Despite being heavily outnumbered by the Burmese who were led by scores of war elephants, local garrisons of Mongol troops were able to decisively defeat the Burmese at the battle of Ngasaunggyan. Kublai Khan then sent Nasir al-Din, the son of his trusted retainer Saiyid Ajall, into Burma with the objective of taking Bagan. The Mongols continued their southward advance into Burma until heat and exhaustion forced them to return to China.

Marco Polo arrived in Burma as the official envoy of Kublai Khan in 1278, a year after the Mongols defeated the Burmese at the battle of Ngasaunggyan. He describes a battle that took place the previous year in the Vochan valley between the Mongol cavalry and a much larger Burmese army. Despite having over 2,000 war elephants and a combination of 60,000 horsemen and light infantrymen, a force of 12,000 well-equipped Mongol cavalrymen was able to defeat the Burmese. Unable to confront the Burmese war elephants head on, the Mongol cavalry dismounted and launched volley after volley of arrows at the elephants. Frightened by the